

driven smartbooks and Nokia suddenly reviving work on Maemo (its Linux platform for UMPCs), you can see why observers suddenly feel that Linux is on its way back to the computing mainstream.

Android on smartbooks: the challenges

Of course, it would be very premature for those in the open source camp to start popping the champagne. We have not yet seen a commercial smartbook or an Android-driven computer in the market yet. And are not likely to for a few months. But analysts are quick to point out that Android is best suited to take advantage of smartbooks as it is designed for a mobile interface. And being open source, it can be tweaked very easily to meet the needs of different devices. Of course, there is nothing stopping a user from installing Windows on a smartbook, but the desktop version of Windows is not designed to take advantage of mobility features like HSPA connectivity or GPS, and this would stop the device from functioning at its best. Yes, Windows does have a mobile avatar, but its popularity is very limited in the phone segment, which is dominated by Symbian. What's more, Android is perhaps the first Linux/open source OS to have caught the public imagination, mainly because of Google's involvement in it. With Android powering Linux devices, they might finally acquire that quality rarely found in the Linux world—aspirational value!

But these are early days. The ball is now squarely in the court of the developer community to come up with an interface and

applications that will make Linux the killer OS for smartbooks. Right now, there is a lot of optimism, but a great deal of confusion—people are not even sure whether all smartbooks will have touchscreens or whether they will be keypad/keyboard driven. Similarly, critics have been quick to point out that the Android platform does not have the kind of applications that most smartphone users need—we are still waiting for a viable mobile version of OpenOffice.org and of Firefox.

Compatibility with different hardware will also be an issue. And then there is the threat of Microsoft, which many feel could just tweak its Windows Mobile platform to meet the needs of smartbooks. There are rumours circulating that Windows Mobile 7 will actually be like Windows 7 in its interface, while incorporating the mobility-friendly features of Windows Mobile. Now, that would make it a formidable challenger in the smartbook segment.

All this is, of course, just speculation. As of now, what we do know is that there is a new gadget in town called a smartbook. And that in all probability, it will come loaded with an OS based on Linux. We do not know how long this state of affairs will persist. But the very fact that it exists, provides an enormous opportunity for Linux to return to the mainstream! **END** 

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